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Jon Hendricks

Vocalist Jon Hendricks was born in Newark, Ohio in 1921. He has taken the vocalese style of singing pioneered by King Pleasure and Eddie Jefferson to a virtuoso level and is a household name with jazz fans around the world. His unique re-working of Basie standards with Lambert, Hendricks and Ross and later Joe Williams, established a new style of vocal jazz in the late 50s and this trio recorded such classic tunes as "Cloudburst," "Gimme That Wine" and "Centerpiece." His production "Evolution of the Blues" became a hit at the 1960 Monterey Jazz Festival and Jon is currently working on a revival of this show. He is in constant demand as a lyricist, performer and spokesman for jazz and appears at major jazz venues here and abroad.

Jon was interviewed in New York City by Monk Rowe on October 18, 1995.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we're filming today for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive and I'm very pleased to have with me Mr. Jon Hendricks.

JH: Thank you, Monk. That's a great name.

MR: It works. I'll bet you've said that a few times.

JH: Yes, I have.

MR: It's great to have the greatest exponent of a very specific style of jazz singing with us, and I hope we can see if we can understand that a little better today. You go back a ways, and I read that you used to be accompanied by Art Tatum?

JH: For ten years in a night club in Toledo, my home town, also his home town, and I knew him all my life actually. Because I started singing at nine, professionally. I started at seven. As I say in my act, I started singing at seven, professionally at nine, before that I was a bum. I laid around the house and didn't do nothing.

MR: You took a few years off in your early life, okay. We can understand that.

JH: But Art and I played all the amateur shows around Toledo. He started out on the violin, you know. His ambition was to be another Jascha Heifetz. And his mother thought to help him with his violin she'd get him a piano. And he set down to that piano and boy —

MR: That's all she wrote.

JH: That was it. That was it.

MR: Was he a good accompanist?

JH: Yes. Oh, absolutely, absolutely.

MR: Because we are so used to hearing him playing so much piano, that he must have been able to cut back a little bit to accompany the singing. Or how did that work?

JH: Well what he did was he played a lot you know, but he left the melody open so that what he played surrounded you. Like a good arranger would do. Like Claus Ogerman did for

those tunes without the strings, you see what he did. He just filled everything out. And that's what I did. He knew the melody to everything. So he left that to you to sing it. And everything else he just put there.

MR: The stuff you were singing at that time, the music, was it jazz? Or was it the popular songs of the day?

JH: At that time the music of America was jazz. Popular music exists because of jazz, you know. I mean the rhythm is the key. What makes country & western music you know, is the beat. Because before that it was "Greensleeves."

MR: Music from across the ocean.

JH: Yeah. It was the ballads or the European music is simply music with the rhythm removed. When Stravinsky put the African rhythms back in to European music with Le Sacre du printemps in 1921 I think it was, it caused two days of rioting in Paris you know.

MR: Yeah. They didn't know what to do with that.

JH: Yeah. Because they hadn't heard that. But that's the essence of American popular music is the, as Duke says, "it don't mean a thing if it ain't got that swing."

MR: Did you have a musical family?

JH: No. I had a religious family. My father was a minister. My mother was a Sister in the church, and she wrote lyrics to spirituals. She was very good. That's where I came by my love of rhyming and literature too, because she always read a lot. And I used to help my father with his sermons by, you know, he would have me pick passages from the Bible and then he would preach a sermon based on this certain passage or passages. Like I'd pick a passage of maybe two or three verses you know. And he would expand on that and I would listen to him. At first I would read the passages you know, and I would not understand the meaning. Because in the first place I was too young. But then I went to church that Sunday and I heard him preach this whole sermon on these two or three verses, I was amazed at the body of knowledge that can be contained in such a short space as far as words were concerned.

MR: Yeah. He just expanded on that.

JH: Yeah. So even to this day when I write a lyric I try to construct a line so that within that line there's a whole chapter of a book, if you stop and think about it. And that's where I learned that from.

MR: Maybe that's why a writer, I think it was *Time* magazine called you "The James Joyce of Jive."

JH: I was so flattered by that. I went and read James Joyce over again, because I had read him when I was in English, because that was my major you know. And I had heard Joyce like

and think of tunes. And I didn't pay that much attention. But when that man said that about me in *Time* magazine, I went back and read James Joyce and I see why he saw fit to do that. Because Joyce used language the way jazz players used the songs they played and the point of departure. He took language and departed into whole worlds of words.

MR: When did you get the first idea of listening to an improvised solo, and doing what you do with it.

JH: I have to laugh because I'm just thinking about all that stuff. Because I'm going to write my book. So I started to thinking about that and it's amazing. Where I got the idea to write with what is now known as vocalese, was when I was a kid, you know, it was in the middle of the depression. And you have no idea how hard times were in the depression. I mean people talk of hard times now. These are luxury hard times, you know, compared to those times. Redd Foxx had something in his act about that. He said "times were so hard that one day my father was sitting on the front step and he hollered up and said, 'Martha — the garbage man's coming.' And she said, 'tell him to leave two cans.'"

MR: Oh, that is hard.

JH: That's right, times were tough and there were, my father and my mother and 15 children. Twelve boys and three girls in the depression. So it was very, very difficult. So I didn't have nickel to buy popcorn, and a dime to go into the movie theater. With all my brothers and sisters you know my father just couldn't afford to give everybody a dime to get in and a nickel to buy popcorn. So we all had to find some way of finding 15 cents on Saturdays to go to the movies. And so my brothers would go out and get what we called "junk" you know they would go junking, which was they'd walk through the alleys. At that time every street had a back part which was the alley, and people would throw away things — papers, old lamps that broke you know — all these they would pick up in a wagon or a cart and take them to the junkyard. And you'd be surprised how everything is worth something. And this guy would buy the things off them maybe for 25 cents. Well there's a quarter, it means you can take somebody else to the movies, and you've got a nickel for the popcorn you know. So we used to do that. I used to go to the men's room of the bus station or the train station and when somebody was going to put a nickel into the slot that goes to the lavatory, I'd say, "wait a minute! Just give me the nickel." And I would crawl down underneath, open the door, and make 15 cents. After I did that three times I would go to the movies and have a nickel for the popcorn. Then I found out something else. People played the juke box. And it cost a nickel. So I learned all that stuff that was on the juke box, and I could hum most of those songs. So I said why don't you learn those songs? And so I would learn the solos and then I would stand in front of the juke box and then when somebody was going to play I'd say. "wait a minute, don't put

by Jimmy Lunceford. I said, "don't put it in there, give it to me and I'll sing it." And they couldn't' resist that. So you know they would give me the nickel and I would say [scats]. I would sing the whole thing — solo and all — and the whole place would be —

MR: Oh that's fantastic. And how old were you then?

JH: I was about 13. And I would earn enough money, and then I would go to the movies. And I forgot about that until I wrote "Sing a Song of Basie." And I said, hey, yeah, I know how to do this.

MR: I have to ask you about that. I mean this, I know I'm skipping some years in your life —

JH: I hope so.

MR: You did some non-music jobs I'll bet on the way.

JH: Oh, yes.

MR: Paid some dues?

JH: I say that's the period at which my feet touched the ground, you know? Because music keeps you up in the air you know.

MR: Right. It kind of makes you appreciate when you can make a living making music, from the other things.

JH: Absolutely. The most wonderful gift in the world I think.

MR: Well when you did this "Sing a Song of Basie," it seems like a tremendous amount of writing went into this.

JH: Yes.

MR: Did it take a long time?

JH: It took a shorter time to write it than it did to learn it. Like I can attest to the spirituality of the creative process you know, and there have been symposia on that, people have talked about that. And I know that when you're in the process of creating something, you become God's pencil, you know? Because you're watching the pencil to see what's coming out. So if you're the one doing it, you wouldn't have to do that. You would know what's coming out. But all during "Sing a Song of Basie" I would be watching the pencil to see what was coming. And it was almost like revealed writing. It just came. And to this day if I do a lyric I do the whole band with the solos and all in one draft. And I go back and maybe I have to change one or two words here, but it just pours out.

MR: Wow. It sounds like how Mozart wrote, from what I've read.

JH: Yeah. I think it's revealed. I think that's the way it is.

MR: And this was one of I think the first ones where you did multi-tracking on this, obviously.

JH: This was the first everything. It's the first time the lyrics were put on the back. I insisted on that because I said look, nobody's going to know what we're singing.

MR: And it's like a vocabulary lesson in what was happening at the time. I mean what do they

JH: Then it didn't have a name. Leonard Feather gave it the name "vocalese." And that stuck. But Ralph Gleason, when he was writing for the *San Francisco Chronicle*, wrote a wonderful column on what you just remarked on. He said some day in the future, sociologists will refer to Jon Hendricks' lyrics to see how people spoke in the 50s and 60s. And I thought — I was very flattered by that. It was very flattering. But I think it's true. Because the lyrics are full of vulgate expressions that were very much in use at one time but are not very much in use today.

MR: And you had quite a wonderful association with Count Basie.

JH: Oh, yeah. It was gorgeous. He was a great man. I mean he was great in such a quiet way. There wasn't any flamboyance about him. What it was about him, I think was his magnetism. He just set still and was quiet. But nothing happened until he moved. I mean the band would be on the bandstand, and everybody would be sitting there and he'd come and make that introduction, and the whole band would come to life. He and Duke Ellington had that same thing, and Basie was so honest. You know he was such an honest man that it was funny, I mean it was joke the way he would just let the truth come out of his mouth. Like one time we went to London with him. And he asked me to come by his hotel you know, because he was going to do an interview with the *London Times*. And he was kind of worried about it, and wanted to make sure that everything went well. So he wanted me there in case I had to translate for him for the reporter.

MR: Yeah there was some difference between how the English language was used between the *London Times* and —

JH: So this man sits down and he says, "tell me, Mr. Bahsie" he says "you have a style of play-ing the piano" he says, "you don't seem to play too many notes. You're sort of economical in your style of playing." He says, "how did you arrive at such a style?" And Basie said, "I just can't play no more piano." And I was sitting there and I went into the bathroom and cracked up. Because it was so true but totally unexpected. And then when we saw the article the next day, the guy remarked on how Mr. Basie was so — what did he call it — so modest. He said he was so modest. He wasn't modest, he was telling the truth. You know the "One O'clock Jump" if you listen to that record, Basie could only play in E flat.

MR: In E flat?

JH: When he started out that was it. E flat. And that song is in D you know when the band comes in. So he plays his two choruses in E flat, and he makes the modulation to D and the band plays.

MR: And then he can kind of lay out and just do his thing here and there.

JH: Find a note, man.

JH: Well he became a great piano player. He became a great piano player. Because this was at the beginning. But boy, he could play, he really could play. Because he found exactly the right note and the right time. And if you were playing in his band, if you were soloing, and you ran out of ideas, he was listening, and he would play something and feed you, you know, the next whole chorus, with just one or two notes you know.

MR: Such a gift. It's a good lesson for younger players too — the economy of notes and what a few notes can do.

JH: Exactly. Exactly.

MR: On the sequel to the Basie thing you used Joe Williams as your fourth voice.

JH: Yes, yes, that was the best time of my whole life, singing-wise, to have Dave, Annie and Joe — oh, that was a perfect group. Because Joe's beautiful, rich, syrupy baritone you know, at the bottom of that stuff, just what it needed. It was so wonderful. I'll never forget that. In fact we still talk about it, Joe and I still talk about that. He still talks about that. You know it was so wonderful. And he was just like a student. You know he didn't act like a star or anything. He says, "well what do you want me to do?" And I says, "well I want you to do J.J. Johnson's solo on 'Rambo.'" And he says, "okay." And he really did it, you know. He hit the notes right. He was beautiful. He was great.

MR: How has recording changed from then 'til now for you?

JH: Well, a lot. A lot. I think in the first place, not just recording but the whole music industry. In those days the music industry was wisely left to the artists, you know. The heads of the all the record companies were musicians and artists. They had their business departments with their lawyers and their bookkeepers and their bean counters and all, they were there. But the decisions, you know, that affected the work, were made by artists, so that you had great productivity from all the record companies. The guy, the head of RCA Victor, played with the Philadelphia Symphony Orchestra. He played the clarinet and the bassoon. The head of Columbia Records was Goddard Lieberson, worked in the English music halls. He played piano and would do a dance for you. He was an artist. And it was the same with Decca was headed by Milt Gabler. Milt Gabler opened up his own record company at 17 and knew the names of every great jazz musician, and had a great love for the music. But nowadays, they have taken the lawyers and the accountants and the bean counters from the business department, and put them in charge of the music. Well, put a fox in charge of the chicken coop and see how many chickens you have left at the end of the summer. You'll have a lot of feathers, but there won't be no chickens. And that's the way it is. You've got a lot of people recording, but where is the great art?

MR: That's kind of a shame. But you still manage to put out some good product. And it's

JH: Well that's a matter of sheer necessity. I say in my act, the only way to find good young jazz singers today is you have to raise them yourself. And it's actually true you know. Because people go to school to study jazz at the Berklee School of Music, the Manhattan School of Music, where my daughter is now incidentally, and to give you an example of their attitude, we're going on a little mini-tour next Tuesday. We're going to go to Bucharest and sing in Romania, then do several dates in Germany and then go to Paris and do an opening of a night club. Manhattan School of Music won't let my daughter out of her jazz studies to come and do a jazz gig with me, who, I'm a school unto myself. It's unbelievable.

MR: She would learn a year's worth with you.

JH: Well she already has been singing with us for several years and she knows a lot. But the experience — she could come back and speak to the other students about. You know, to me it's just like standing on your head and writing a commentary on life. Because it's a backwards way of looking at things. And you find this now very prevalent. You have people coming out of jazz schools into the jazz scene, without the main thing they need. They have the notes you know. They can play all the notes [scats] up and down every scale. And they know the names of every chord. But they don't know anything about the culture that made the music possible. They don't know anything about the society from which the music came, of which the music is an expression. They don't know anything about the love and the feeling, collectivism, of love for each other, of consideration for your fellow musicians. That's is the key to the music being played really correctly. And there's nothing about that. They know everything from up here. They know the notes on the paper. But the notes on the paper are not the music. The music comes from the heart.

MR: And it's so important because jazz especially was so important in breaking some of the racial problems down.

JH: Absolutely. Benny Goodman is an American social hero. He is a hero in the development of American society. Outside of music, Benny Goodman is a social hero. Because his love for the music was so pure that he just did not understand why he couldn't have Lionel Hampton in his band, and then Charlie Christian and then Teddy Wilson you know. He just didn't understand that. And the bean counters and the accountants and the lawyers, they tried to explain to him, "Benny, you'll lose your show, they will not renew you on the 'Camel Caravan' if you do this." So they gave him all those very hard and fast business reasons. But he refused to understand it. He said, "I like those guys."

MR: They play the music I want, so they stay, right?

JH: So he did what people have to march now to achieve. And it's because of the power of the music, a love of the music. I was just talking to Lionel's man over there. And I asked

at the Blue Note." I said, "that's no problem," I said, "long as the music plays, he's all right, he'll be cool. It's when the music stops that they have to worry."

MR: Yeah. Well you know on one of his last records there it says "For the Love of Music." And that's what it's all about.

JH: Exactly.

MR: If I can jump back for one minute — I have to ask you about "Cloudburst." I mean the song "Cloudburst" was that based on a Wardell Gray solo?

JH: No, no. That's a tragic story. Because you know, all of the guys that came out of the band when the big bands began to break up, you know Chic Webb's band, all of them went into some aspect of the music business to try to continue to make a living with music. And Chic Webb's guitarist, his name was Leroy Kirkland. And he was one of Chic Webb's main arrangers you know, a fine musician. And he was around Broadway trying to make a living selling songs, writing songs, conducting rhythm & blues recording dates you know, doing anything he could. And he finally got a gig from MGM Records that wanted him to do an album of great rock type, rhythm & blues type, flag waving type songs. And so he thought this was beneath him. But the money was good. So he figured okay, he would make this album. And there was a song that he wanted to record on the album called "Cloudburst" that was written by two great jazz musicians, Leroy himself and a trumpet player named Benny Harris who was a legendary trumpet player and played with Dizzy, played with Bird for a while, but died of an overdose very early. But a very hip musician. And they wrote this song called "Cloudburst." So he figured well since some part of the tune, I wrote part of it, I'll call the album "Cloudburst" and I'll call myself "Claude Cloud" and I'll call the orchestra "the Thunderclaps." So it was "Claude Cloud and his Thunderclaps," with the album featuring "Cloudburst." And he felt well that'd be a good place to hide — whoever heard this album and decided, oh, man, what is Leroy doing? And it was a smash hit. So poor Leroy Kirkland collecting all that money, and very sad because all these years of struggle, nobody still knows his name.

MR: He pulled a fast one on himself.

JH: On himself.

MR: Oh man, that's great.

JH: You know we used to joke when we saw him, we'd say, "Claude" — he'd say, "don't!"

MR: But that solo you did on that tune goes by —

JH: Sam the Man Taylor is the one that played that.

MR: Yeah. It goes by so fast. But every time I hear it I go, how did you do that? How did you do that? Did they record you at 33 and then press it at 78 or something? I mean it's just —

JH: Well I think I should tell you, I actually studied law. My major was English, my minor was history, and I was a law student. And I had 18 months to get my law degree. And I got the only A in speech class in four years. And I got the only A in the creative writing class in seven years. And so I was a bit of a academic star you know for that, because the guy that wrote the book on creative writing, Dr. Milt Marks, was well known. I think he won a Pulitzer Prize and he's well known at all university levels, especially in all the English departments. So I knew how to use words. And I knew all about that. But as far as speaking that fast, I would have said to myself, I have to slow this down. But I found that when I started to sing it, the speed aspect of it disappeared. I just sang it.

MR: It's a classic, I'll tell you that.

JH: Well, but that's a very high praise. That's high praise coming from you. I thank you very much for that. Because all it is is it's fun to me. I love it.

MR: I thought that was one of your best albums, really, with everybody boppin' on it. I know there are certain tunes that seem to follow you around, like with Lionel and "Flyin' Home," he's still recording it, and then you did "Everybody's Boppin.'"

JH: I did a lyric to "Flyin' Home." He just asked me about it so I have to look for it. It's in one of my storage boxes. You know I have stuff in storage, because I have a house in Mill Valley. And the stuff that I have just won't fit in the average New York apartment. If I put all my stuff, as George Collins says, in my New York apartment, we'd have to move, you know. So I have to store stuff. But I have that lyric to "Flyin' Home." I have to go to the storage now and find that.

MR: I hope it's not like what I've heard about Milt Hinton's basement or something you know.

JH: I saw Milt yesterday at the shoot. 86. I told him I said, "did you hear the song that Mr. Clark Terry sang to me?" He says, "no, which one?" [sings] "Who is Milton Hinton's lady? Mona." He fell down.

MR: What a wonderful — What's in the immediate future for you? European tour?

JH: Well I'm going on this tour. I'm getting together another album and I'm going to do a vocalese project. I'm going to lyricize and sing the Miles Davis "'Round About Midnight" album. Yeah. That's going to be a labor of love. I love that album. I think it's the best jazz album I've heard since Bird and Diz.

MR: Do you work at the piano when you do this?

JH: No. I don't know how to play.

MR: You just hear?

JH: I play drums. But I learned from Art Tatum to hear every note in the chord. Because he would make me sing. Like when I was 13, he used to say, "sing this" [scats]. And I'd go,

this club, two shows a night. You know I was billed. I had billing. "Little Jonny Hendricks — the Sepia Bobby Breen." It was a child movie star discovered by, I think it was Eddie Cantor, named Bobby Breen. He made a couple of pictures. One was "Rhythm on the River" and he was a very big star there for a hot minute. And so they named me "Little Jonny Hendricks, the Sepia of Bobby Breen," accompanied by Art Tatum. I mean I've got one of those bills.

MR: I was going to ask. I hope you do.

JH: Yeah. She has one of those handbills, I'm going to put it in my book. But you know Art had me come by his house after junior high school every day. All the other kids would go junking you know, or chasing after the girls or football or baseball. I had to go by Art's house. And he would play these phrases for me to sing. And he'd say, "sing this." And I noticed that his eyes were closed. So I thought well, he must know something. So I said when I started to sing it, I'll close my eyes. You know and I closed my eyes and I found that subliminally or not, I seemed to hear better with my eyes closed. I could hear more clearly, you know like it seemed that my intake process was heightened by that. So as a result of that I never learned to read music. And to this day, musicians send me lead sheets you know. I saw Paquito D'Rivera yesterday. He sent me a lead sheet, something called "No Smoking." And I said, "'Paquito, what are you trying to do, flatter me?" He says, "What do you mean?" I said, "You sent me a lead sheet." He says, "yes, because I want you to put the words to 'No Smoke — '" I said, "Paquito — I don't read."

MR: Play it once for me though, right?

JH: Yeah. He says, "what?" I says, "I don't read music. Send me a tape." You know and that's why I never learned how to read. Because Art made me concentrate on listening. He would say, "listen, listen." So I would go — and I found my hearing increased, increased, until now I hear things I don't even want to hear. I'm walking down the street and I hear snatches of people's conversation. And I almost feel like turning around and walking in front of them and saying, "wait a minute."

MR: You can't say that! Oh, that's amazing.

JH: It's really funny.

MR: Well, I wish we could talk all night here. I wish you the best of luck in your future project, and I can't wait to read your book.

JH: Oh, yes. That's going to be interesting. I'm dredging up things that I had completely forgotten about you know. Like I forgot that I had worked with Art Tatum until I started to think about this book. I never told anybody that. I forgot about it. And there's one really funny incident that I remember, it's really, it's funny but it's also kind of poignant you know. But it also points out the philosophy that we had as my father's children, you

living God. And every man, woman and child on this planet were our brothers and sisters. And never mind that they didn't feel that way, that was their problem. It was our job to remember that we are brothers and sisters to every human being. So I find it solved all the racial problems I might have had. Because I've never really had any. You know, anybody comes to me, I give them the love I would give a brother. So if they have animosity toward me, first it's got to get through that. And that's pretty hard. That's pretty hard to get through. So I find I have no problems you know. But I also found that it made me blind in a funny kind of way because at about 13 or 14 I sang a song made popular on the radio by a guy named Skinnay Ennis. Spelled S-K-I double N-A-Y. I don't know why, but, and he sang this song [sings] "the object of my affections, can change my complexion, from white to rosy red, oohh. Every time you hold my hand — " And I thought, oh, I'll sing this song. So I would sing that song, and people would throw me money. Of all my repertoire, I made more money out of that song. And I used to say, "that's my big hit" you know. And it wasn't until I got with Dave and Annie, and I was 35 years old, that I realized —

MR: What you were saying.

JH: No wonder they threw me all this money.

MR: Man oh man.

JH: But isn't that funny? But that is funny, poignant, grim, but funny. It's just funny you know. Because if I had accepted race, I would never have sung that song. But I have never accepted that. I don't accept anything but God's children. And I read Paul, God is no respecter of person. So who is man to cause problems, and to have all this racial — all these politicians talking about the problems between black and white, already are expressing gross ungodliness. And lack of belief in any real God you know. And this I've had no part of that. I would not blaspheme in that manner.

MR: We can all learn from some of those comments. That's wonderful.

JH: I just will not have anything to do with that. Mankind? That's me. I'm there. If you want something for mankind? Okay. But I will not compartmentalize it you know.

MR: Well on behalf of Hamilton College, it's been a great, great pleasure having the poet laureate of jazz. There's another one.

JH: Leonard Feather. You know what we called Leonard? God rest his soul I loved him, he was a good friend of mine. But we called him "Learned Father." Well you know why, because Leonard was the definitive jazz critic. You know most guys who play, take umbrage at being criticized — by being criticized by somebody that can't play. Leonard wrote and recorded the first three tunes on Dinah Washington's first album, and played piano on the date. So there you are. He has a right.

JH: He has bona fides. So when he criticizes, you are forced to pay attention.

MR: Well thanks so much for your time.

JH: I thank you very much for the opportunity.

MR: It's been wonderful.